nineteen years after Ashoka's coronation. The Ajivikas are not mentioned here. Instead, the king speaks in the first person to say that 'this cave in the very pleasant Kha(latika mountain) was given by me for (shelter during) the rainy season.'[6] It is possible that wandering mendicants in need of reliable shelter during the rainy season used this cave. There may also have been free-standing structures in Barabar since at places the stone foundations of walls peep out of the ground. Whether they were contemporaneous with the caves excavated on the orders of Ashoka remains uncertain. In any case, recipients of such a substantial royal donation had to be influential; so, had they approached the emperor in person? Or did Ashoka, along the lines of the rescripts issued around the same time—those highlighting the importance of respect to religious people—create these structures out of regard for such sentiments? On the whole, after the long hortatory epigraphs, the brevity of Ashoka's donative records at Barabar seems both striking and somewhat unsatisfactory.

Much more is known about the technology and design of construction of the Barabar caves which, like the writing of public edicts on rock surfaces, represented an innovation. With their inclining walls and invariably rounded roofs, they imitate the architecture of more humble wooden and bamboo dwellings. They appear to create in rock the form of habitations in which ascetics usually felt comfortable. Except that, unlike huts, these are rooms of high quality. The walls are plain but, because of the proportions of the rooms, have a highly developed aesthetic appearance which, in turn, is enhanced by the remarkable polish. The lustrous inner surfaces actually are mirror-like in their effect. These surfaces enhance every sound inside the caves and so, living in them, one imagines, presupposed perfect silence. It was this proclivity of the caves to echo so unusually that is the anti-spiritual centrepoint of E.M. Forster's *A Passage to India* (1924). Forster comments on aspects of the Marabar caves (a thinly disguised reference to Barabar), their lack of ornamentation and sculpture, a remarkable echo in them, the